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Confidential

No 264



Legation of the United States
Peking, June 13, 1873
Frederick F. Low
to
Department of State



Subject

Japanese Embassy and its business.

States what he has gathered in conversations with the Ambassador as to the objects he has in view; also what he has done and is doing.

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Legation of the United States
Peking, June 13, 1873

Sir:-

The Japanese Embassy is still in Peking. The Ambassador has called to see me several times, and I have been to see him as often as the state of my health would permit.
The question of priority of rank which at one time seemed likely to hinder the establishing of cordial relations between him and my colleagues has, I am happy

Hon Hamilton Fish
Secretary of State

happy to say been put aside for the present, with an understanding that it shall remain in abeyance until all shall have presented their Letters of credence.

In his conversations with me the Ambassador has spoken freely and with apparent frankness concerning the purport of his mission and the business with which he is charged. There are, he says, only two questions of importance which he desires to discuss with the Chinese Government.

1st Whether China is responsible for the acts of the aborigines on

on the Island of Formosa. If the Government answers this question in the affirmative he will then demand redress and indemnity for the murder of some natives of Loo Choo who were wrecked there a year and more ago; If the answer is in the negative notice will then be given that Japan proposes to send a military force to Formosa to chastise the Savage and semi-civilized tribes that practically hold undisputed possession of the larger part of the Island; and as there are no safe harbors on the

that part of the island where the aboriginies reside, permission will be asked to land troops at one of the ports open to trade, and to march them through Chinese territory that lies between the ports and the points the troops are intended to operate against the Savages.

2d. To ascertain the precise relations between China and Corea — whether the former claims to exercise such control over her as to render China responsible for the acts of the Coreans, or whether the other

others nations must look to Corea alone for redress for wrongs and outrages which her people may commit.

In regard to the Kingdom of Loo Choo, which, as you are aware, Japan has taken formal and actual possession of, he has nothing to say to the Chinese. The Loo-choo islands, he says, are now a part of the Japanese Empire; nor will China or any other country be permitted to question the right of Japan to exercise complete jurisdiction over what was formerly the Kingdom of Loo-Choo.

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The Ambassador has not as yet been afforded an opportunity to present his Letters of Credence to the Emperor, Until this can be done, and his position as representative of Japan is recognized in a fitting and proper manner, no steps will be taken to bring the other questions to the notice of the Imperial Government.

It is understood that negotiations are now pending with reference to the request of the Ambassador, made soon after his arrival in Peking, for an audience

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of the Emperor; it is also understood that at his last interview with the Yamen the Chinese Ministers were given to understand that unless an affirmative answer was returned to his request within a certain number of days, the Embassy would be withdrawn from Peking and relations between the two Governments would cease.

In response the Chinese Ministers said that an answer would be sent within the time named, and intimated that it would be such as would satisfy the Ambassador

Ambassador.

I have the honor to be

Sir,

Your Obedient Servant

Frederick F. Low